

BeThere  

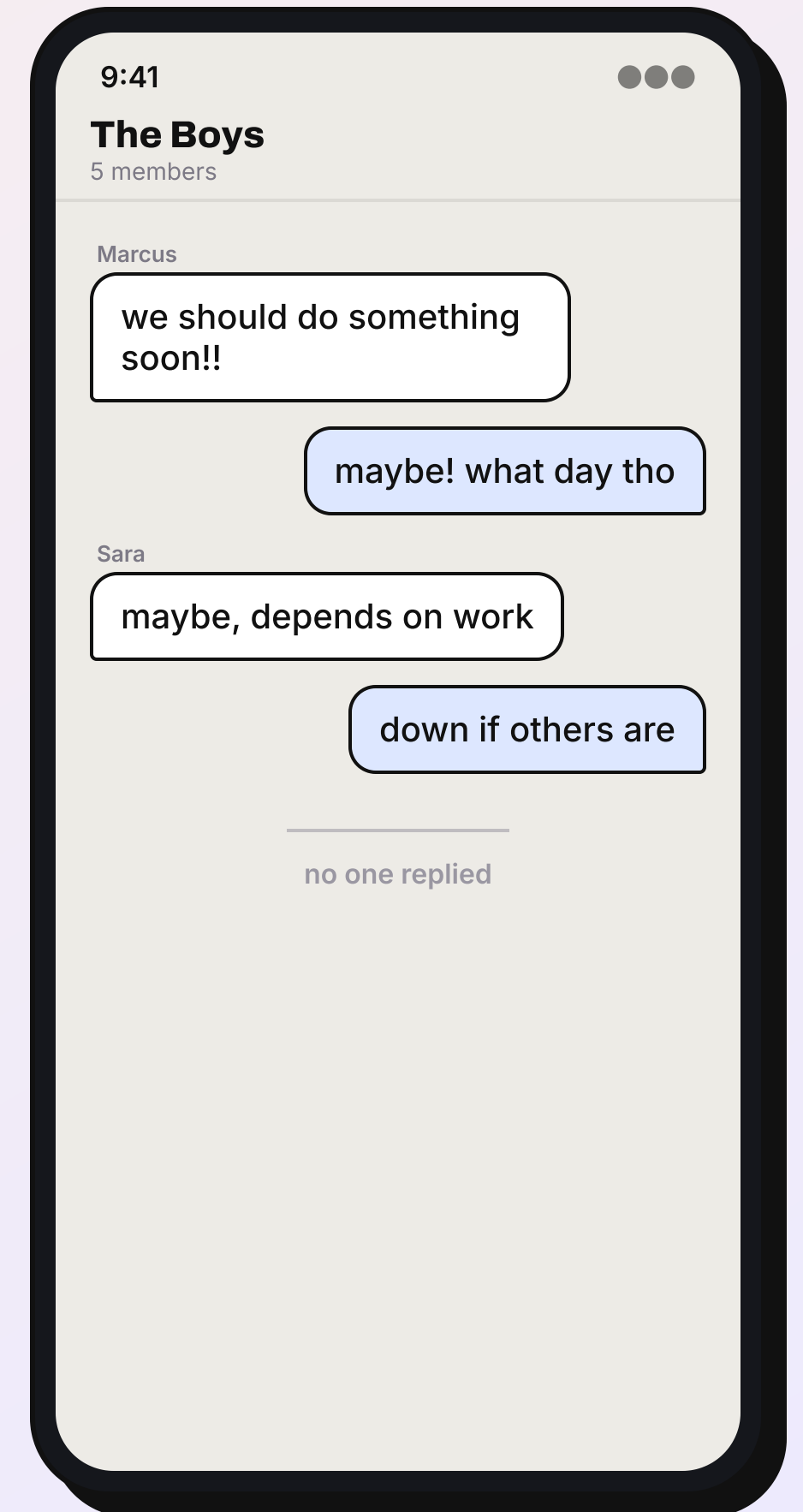
No organiser. No 

It starts with a **spark**

Then a few maybes. One “what day though?”. Two people go quiet.

Nobody said no. The plan just never happened.

3 days later · still nothing



The most connected generation - and the **loneliest**

70%

less time 15-24s spend with friends in person than two decades ago.

U.S. Surgeon General's Advisory on Loneliness, 2023 · American Time Use Survey

40%

of UK 16-24s feel lonely often or very often - the loneliest age group.

BBC Loneliness Experiment, 2018 · n = 55,000

76%

of young adults say seeing friends is how they look after their wellbeing.

ONS, Public Opinions & Social Trends, 2025

They want to see each other. The everyday cost of **making it happen** is the gap BeThere closes.

It dies in the **silence**

The group chat gives you exactly two things.

01

A public “maybe”

A socially safe way to hedge without ever committing. Everyone hedges, so no one is actually in.

02

Infinite time

No deadline forces a decision, so the plan drifts. The longer it sits, the more doubts grow.

“ When someone expresses uncertainty, it cascades uncertainty on the group... that is a website written off.

- Luke, interview

Plans dying is the **norm**

Friend Meetup Survey · n=43 · May 2026

86%

send a "maybe" or nothing at all when they are only slightly unsure.

23/₄₃

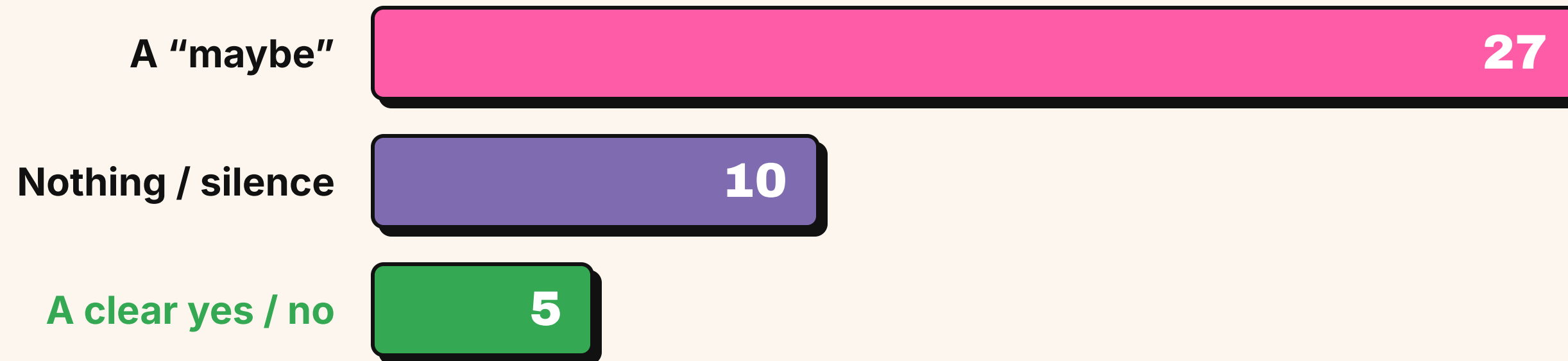
say a third or more of their hangouts get talked about but never happen.

0

people said a **bigger** group made planning easier. 84% said smaller is easier.

What people actually **send**

"When you are only slightly unsure you can make a plan, what do you send?" · n=43



Only **5 of 43** people give a straight answer. The "maybe" is the default - so what if the app didn't offer one?

Straight from the **group chat**

3 rounds of interviews

“

Maybe means I keep the time semi-free - but if anything better comes up, I'll ditch it.

Matthew · the hedge

“

I'm normally the only one who actually wants to do it.

Luca · the asymmetric effort

“

I care less about what we do. I just want to see them.

Felicity · the real goal



Hear it in their own voice

play live

Meet **Millie**

Grounded in the real people we spoke to - Luca and Felicity · survey: only 4 of 43 say they lead



Drop a licensed stock photo - a
~22yo student. NOT an AI-
generated face.

CLICK OR DROP A PHOTO

Millie, 22

Second-year student

Reluctant Initiator

SHE WANTS

To actually see her friends - without always being the one who drags everyone there.

SHE'S FRUSTRATED BY

Being the only one who organises. Proposing feels like a risk - and the group assumes it won't happen.

SHE NEEDS FROM BETHERE

To float an idea without it being **her** idea.

She is not the **only** one

Four ways people dodge committing. BeThere’s job: make everyone behave like the rare **Decisive One**.

The Reluctant Initiator
Wants it to happen, hates being the pusher.
4/43 lead

The Hedger
Keeps it “semi-free”, ditches for something better.
27/43 maybe

The Ghost
Reads it, says nothing, waits for someone else.
10/43 silent

The Decisive One
Says yes or no cleanly. The minority we want.
5/43 clear

DIRECT Everyone who votes · friends named in a conditional · plus-ones & guests

INDIRECT The group chat we replace · venues · Clerk / AWS / Vercel

THE PROBLEM

Plans die in the gap between “we should meet up” and an actual time and place. Nobody wants to be the organiser, the effort is asymmetric, and a public **maybe lets everyone hedge - so the plan quietly dies in a silent chat.**

OPPORTUNITY · HOW MIGHT WE

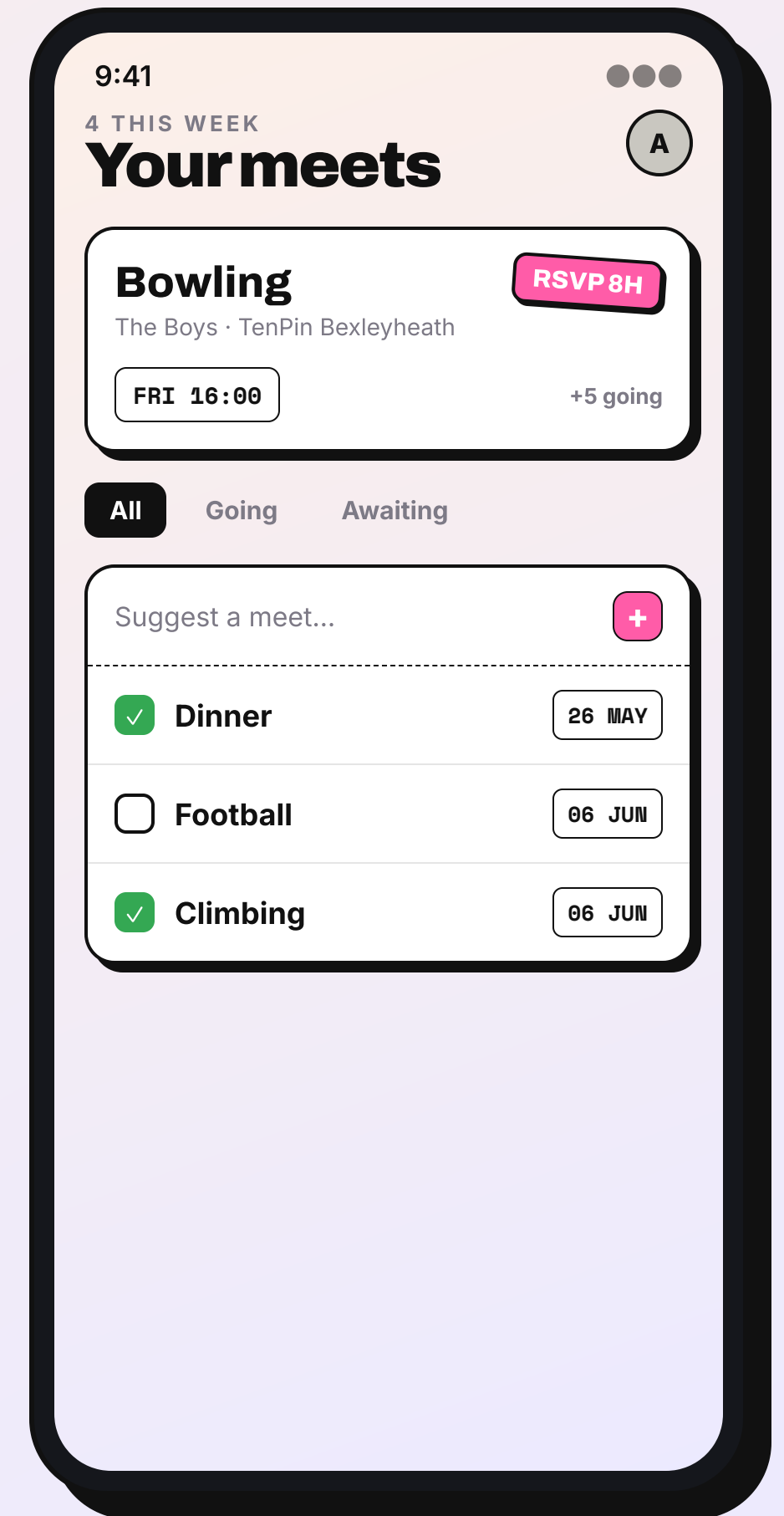
Help a group of friends turn a loose intention to meet into a committed plan - without anyone being the **organiser**, and without the social pressure of a public “maybe”.

SO WE BUILT

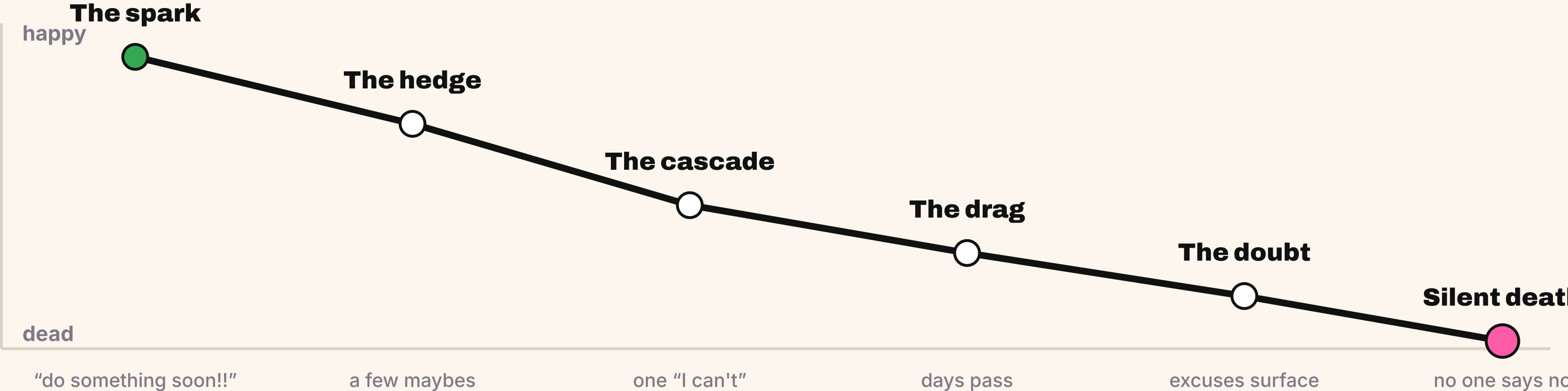
BeThere

One person sends one plan. The group decides.

No organiser, no maybe.



Friday night, on WhatsApp



One person **sends** one meetup

Walkthrough · 1 / 4

9:41

<

Suggest a meet

●

Sent anonymously - no names, just the group

GROUP

The Boys

Reunion

TITLE

Bowling

WHEN - VOTE BETWEEN

Fri 16:00

candidate

Sat 14:00

candidate

Add a time...

+

Send to the group

Candidate times, maybe an activity, a deadline. Sent anonymously.

The group sees the plan - never who proposed it. No one to chase, no one to blame.

INSIGHT

"Nobody likes being the one to push things... anonymity makes it a consensus." - Tom

The group **votes** - no maybe

Walkthrough · 2 / 4

9:41

< Bowling · The Boys

Collecting votes
Pick the times that work 2 DAYS

WHEN

Fri 16:00	+4	☒
Sat 14:00	+1	☐

WHAT

Bowling	+5	☒
Dinner after	+2	☐

Counts are public. Names never are.

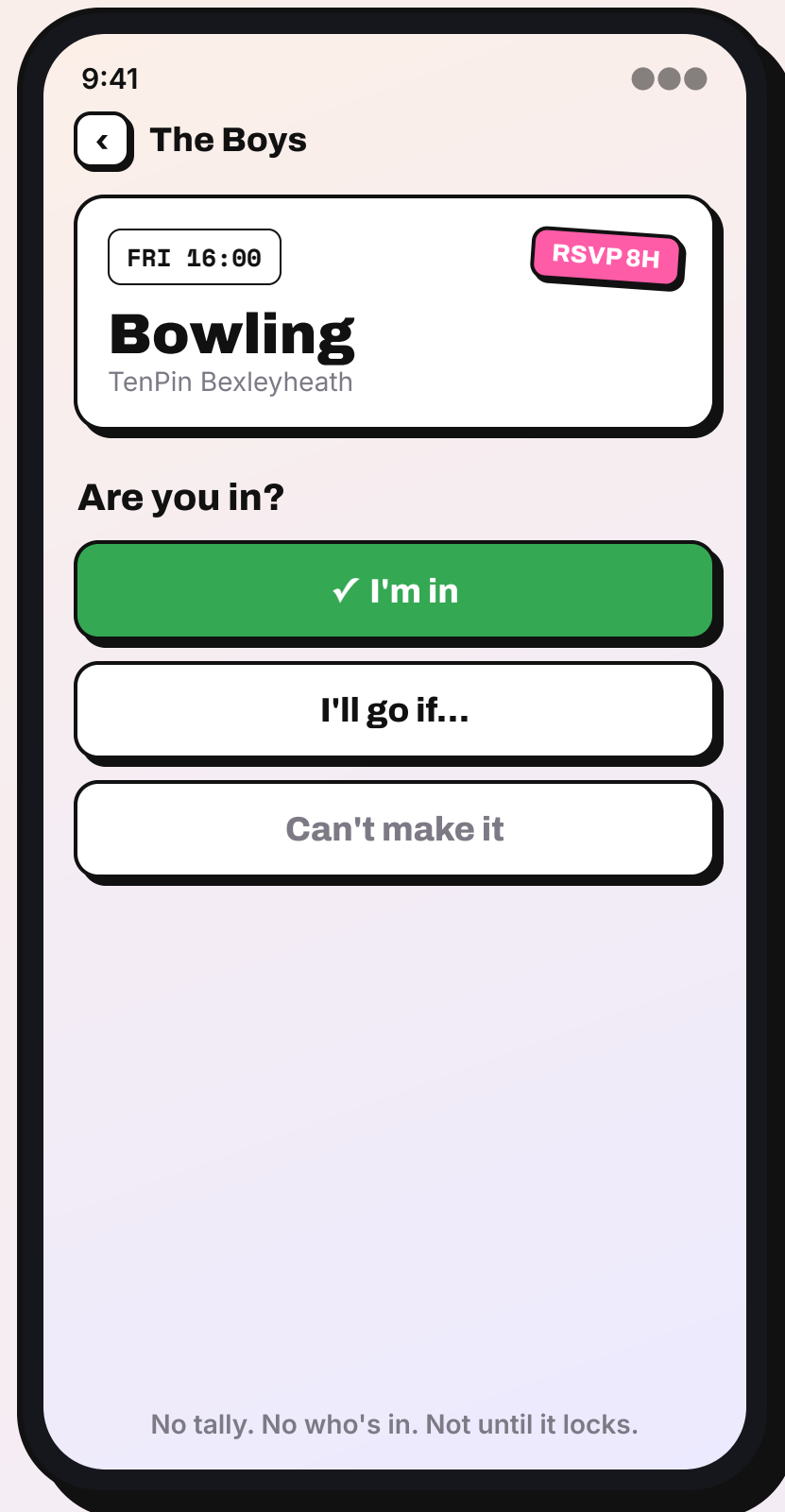
Tap +1. See the momentum. Never see who voted.

Counts are public, names are private. No “maybe” button to hide behind - so one quiet member can’t cascade doubt onto everyone else.

INSIGHT 86% default to a “maybe” - so we removed the maybe.

Then a blind **moment**

Walkthrough · 3 / 4



The deadline auto-picks the winner.
Then you reply **privately**.

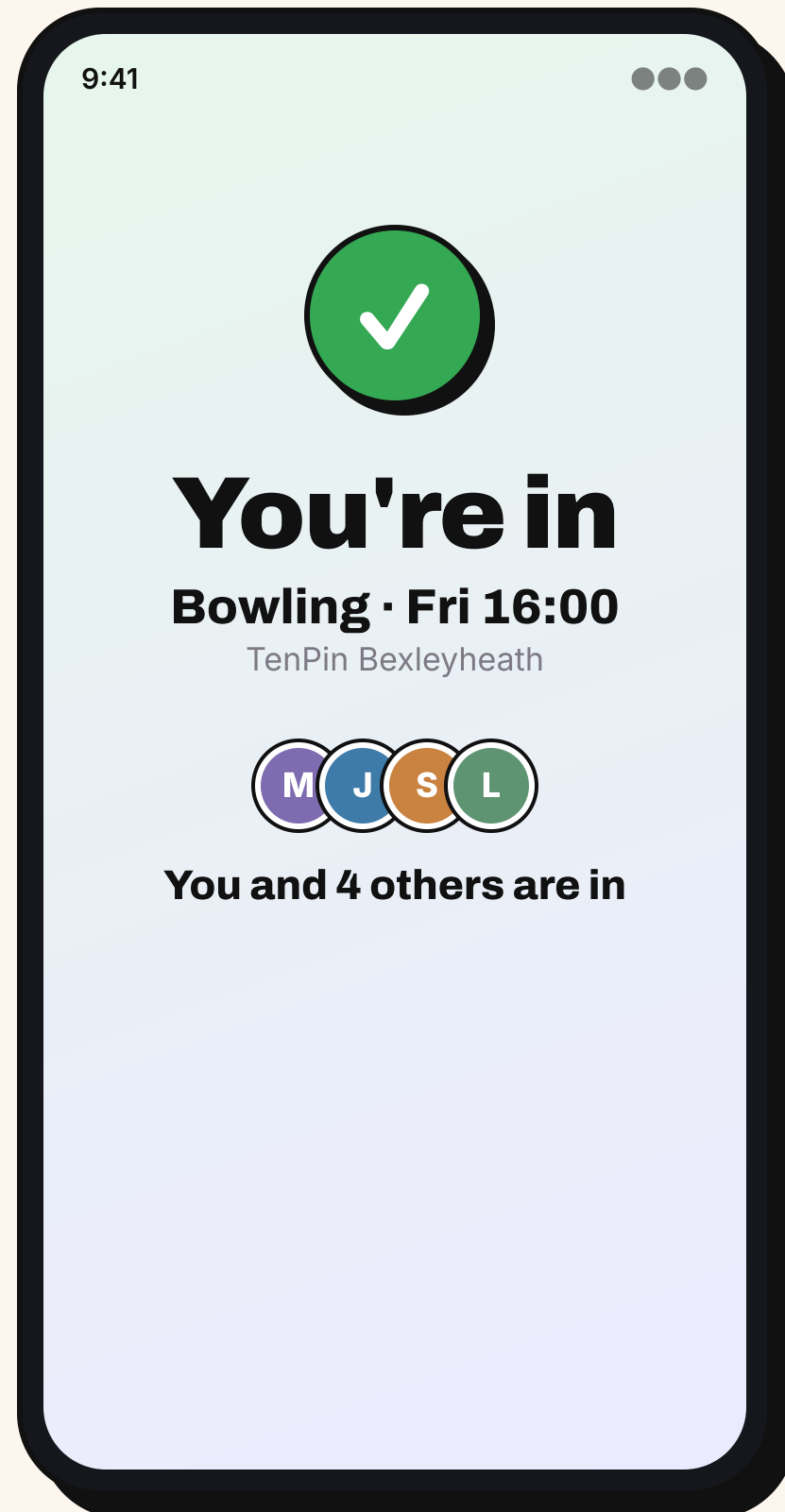
No live tally, no who-is-in. There is nothing to hedge against, so people just answer.

“I'll go if...” the conditional RSVP - defaults to “at least one” friend, never forces a name.

INSIGHT “A deadline with a push - like BeReal, it goes ding ding ding.” - Tom

It clears, or it quietly **fizzles**

Walkthrough · 4 / 4



Enough commit? It **clears** - and the in-crowd is revealed only now.

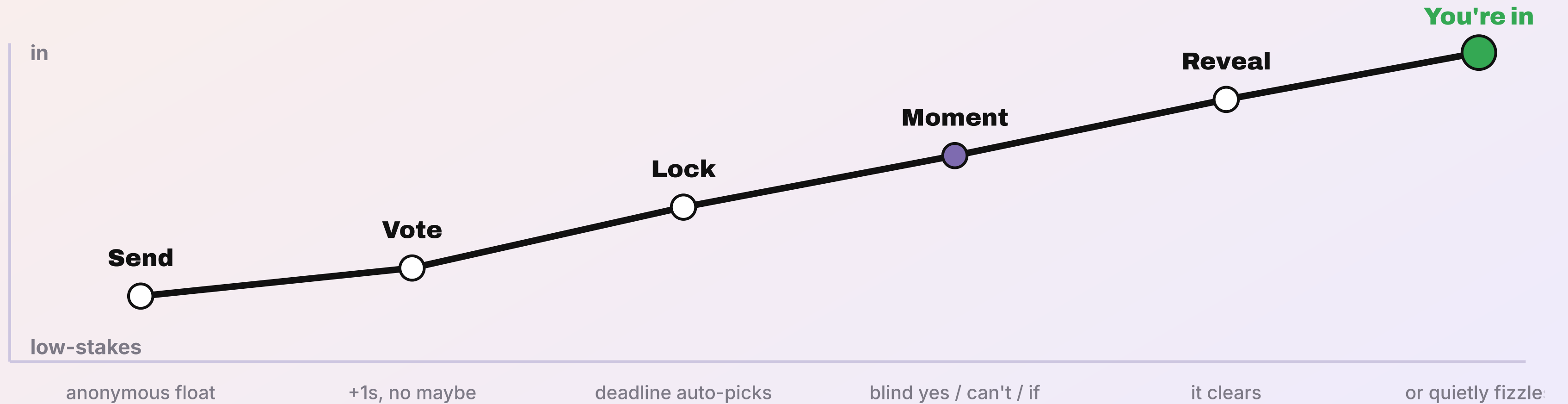
Commitment is shown only after it is safe to show it.

...or it fizzles no trace

If not enough commit, it disappears silently. Hidden from every dashboard. No failure notice, no dead thread - so no blame.

And the curve **inverts**

Same Friday, same friends



Why **anonymous** changes everything

The asymmetric effort was never about logistics - it was about who carries the social cost.

SAID OUT LOUD

The cost lands on Millie

"Millie's making us commit again." One person sticks their neck out - and the group reads it as her ask.



SENT ANONYMOUSLY

The group is converging

The same plan becomes consensus, not a request. No one to push, no one to blame, no one to chase.



Nobody likes being the one to push things. Being anonymous makes it more of a consensus than one person giving a proposal.

- Tom, interview

How the moment stays **blind**

Privacy is a property of the server, not the screen. Three guarantees, enforced in the backend.

Anonymous creator

The creator's id never leaves the server. The client only gets a private "is this me?" boolean.

```
isCreator: boolean
```

No live tally

Counts are returned while collecting, never the voter set. During the moment, nothing about others.

```
respond() → { recorded }
```

Silent fizzle

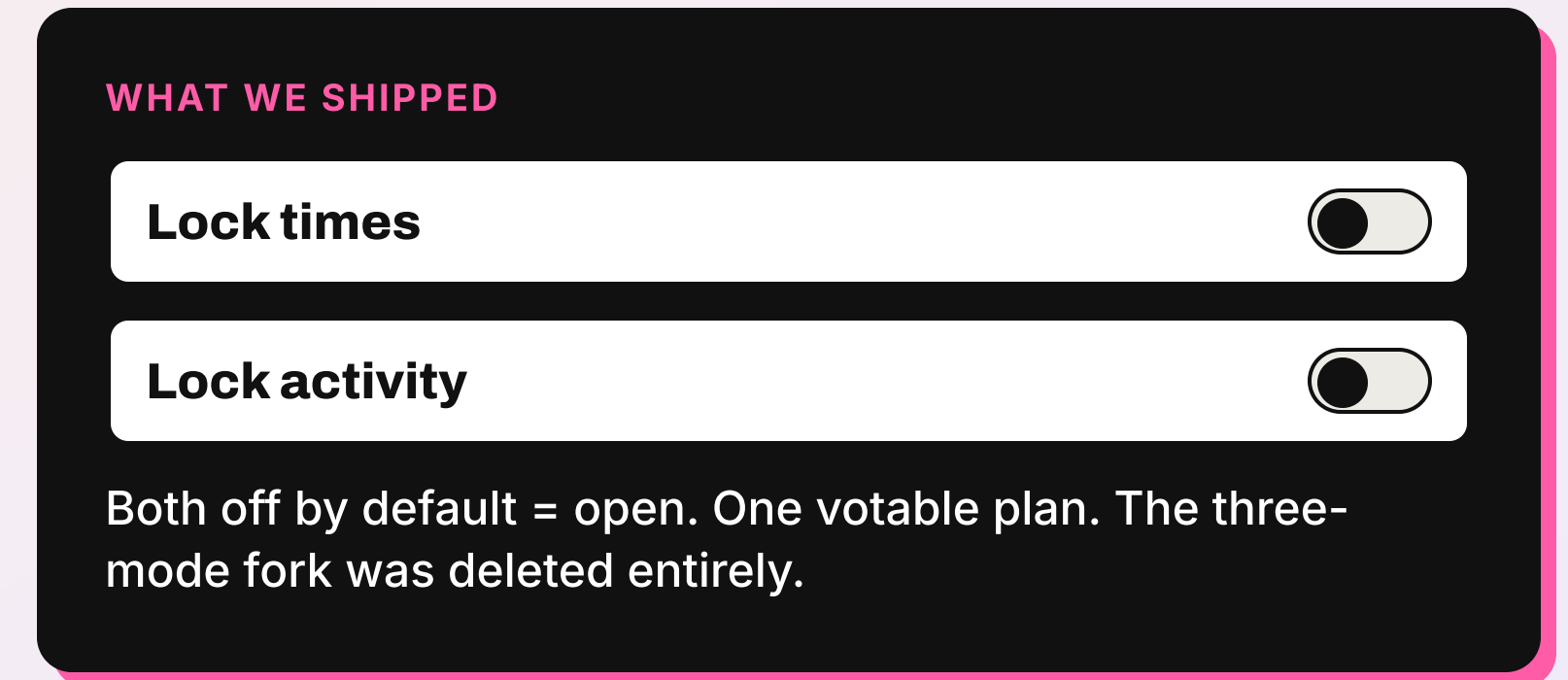
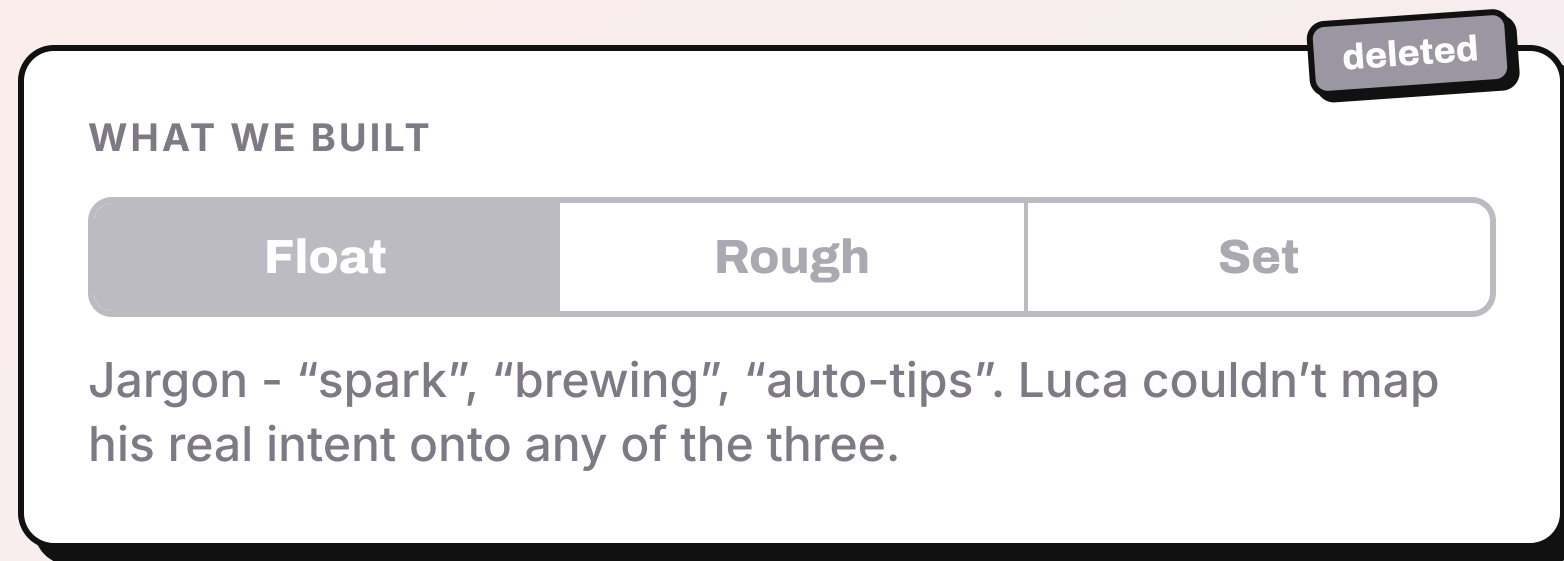
Under quorum, the plan flips to fizzled on the next read and drops out of every dashboard.

```
revealGoing()
```

NO SCHEDULER

A plan settles its own phase lazily - the next time anyone reads it. The privacy boundary lives inside the server's procedures.

Three modes became two **switches**



A real user simplified our information model. **DRP-41**

The finding that **pushed back**

One participant rejected our favourite mechanic.

28th May 2026

Bowling TenPin Bowling
Bexleyheath
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

Joe	☐	at least one of	all of
Bethan	☐		
Adi	☒	are going	
Lily	☒		
Nathan	☐		

CONFIDENTIAL

Paper sketch • M2

THE PUSHBACK

“I would feel so awkward actually writing down which of my friends I wanted to see.”

- Felicity, usability test

WHAT CHANGED

“I'll go if” now defaults to **at least one** friend and never forces a name. **DRP-47**

The download was the real **barrier**

A great flow is useless if Millie can't get her friends onto it.

replaced

WHAT WE HAD

Add from a list of everyone

Add member ▾

Aaron K.

Abigail T.

... 4,201 more, no order

Doesn't scale, no privacy, and it force-joins you to the group.



WHAT WE SHIPPED

A link and a join code

THE BOYS · JOIN CODE

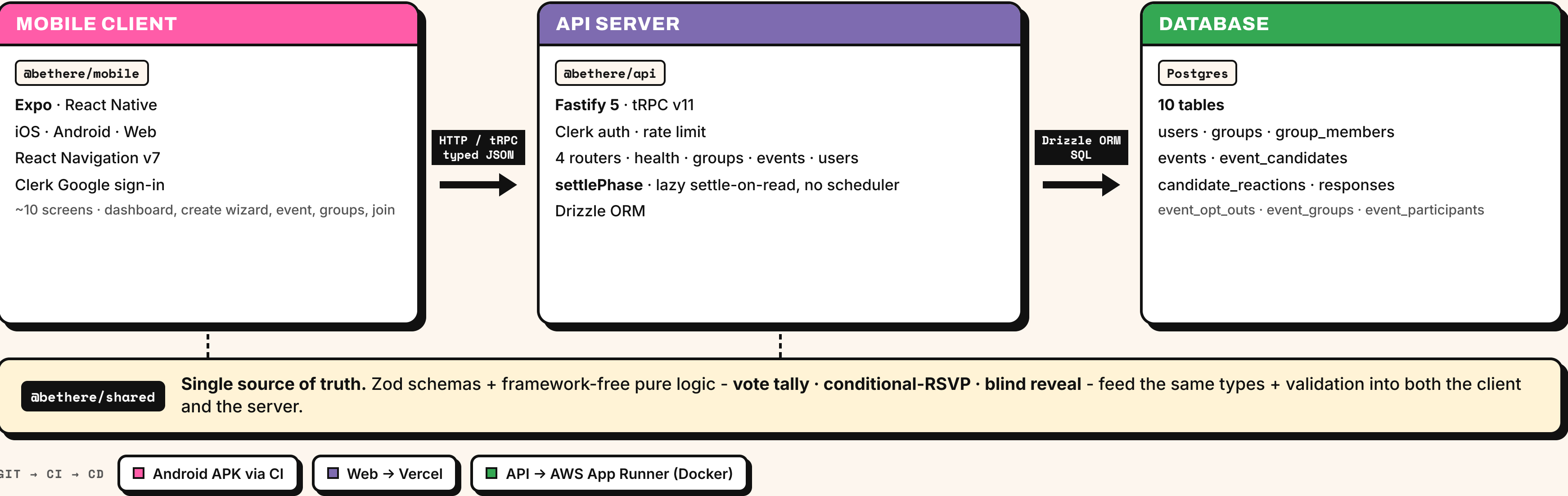
BOWL - 42

Share invite link

No download - the link opens straight in the browser, then drops you into the group.

“It’s just a link - that feels much more seamless.” - Luca DRP-50 · DRP-56

Underthe **hood**



Why this **stack**

tRPC + Zod

@bethere/shared

One schema is the single source of truth. A change that breaks the client fails at **compile time**, not in front of a user. (vs REST + hand-written types, which drift apart.)

Expo / RN

iOS · Android · web

One codebase ships to all three. The web target is exactly what made the **no-download onboarding** possible. (vs native iOS/Android - double the code, no web.)

Postgres + Drizzle

typed SQL

The privacy guarantees - no names, blind tally - live **inside the queries**, server-authoritative and out of reach of the client. (vs Firebase - less control over the privacy logic.)

Lazy resolve

no scheduler

Phases settle on read - **no background job** to drift out of sync, and the privacy boundary stays in one place. (vs a cron scheduler - more to break, same result.)

Built for the **group**

A plan only resolves if the whole group acts - so the interactions are between people, and they feel immediate.

USER TO USER

Anonymous voting - the group +1s times and activities together

The blind moment - everyone commits in the same window

"I'll go if" - your answer depends on other people's

Plus-ones - bring a guest into one meetup, across groups

Shared editing - any member can fix a live plan

RESPONSIVE

Instant +1 - optimistic UI; momentum moves as you tap

Conflict-safe edits - compare-and-set; a stale edit reports a conflict, never clobbers

Settles on read - no waiting on a background job

Honest gap: real-time push is next - today the nudge is device-local.

What went **well**

01

HCD reshaped the product

We deleted our cleverest feature, made anonymity the spine, and kept a real tension honest. It got smaller and sharper because we listened.

02

It works, everywhere

A deployed build on iOS, Android and the web - real friends used it on their own phones, not a mock-up.

03

We met the core need

The two things that kill plans - the public maybe and the lone organiser - are both gone.

What **changed** for them

We set out to make the whole group behave like the rare Decisive One.

The Reluctant Initiator

Floats a plan without it being her ask - no one to chase, no one to blame.

The Hedger

No maybe to hide in; a deadline closes it before second thoughts grow.

The Ghost

A quiet +1 is now a safe signal - silence stops killing plans.

The Decisive One

A blind, deadlined moment that finally makes everyone else answer too.

The bounded claim: we don't cure loneliness. We remove one specific friction that keeps friends apart - and 76% of young adults say seeing friends is how they protect their wellbeing.

Honest about what's

WHAT WE'D DO DIFFERENTLY

Onboarding earlier

It only landed in M4, so our interviews tested the core loop, not the whole journey.

Interview before we build

We slipped once. One of us insisted we validate it properly - now that's the rule.

STILL UNMET · USER NEEDS

- 01** The felt-privacy gap in the conditional - test Felicity's "rank importance" alternative.
- 02** Reliable push notifications - the nudge is currently device-local only.
- 03** Beat the group chat people already live in - the web-first link is the first move.
- 04** We measured intent, not outcome - the study and telemetry are scoped, not yet run.

We won't present an intended result as a measured one.

BeThere

You're in

Be there - without the **organiser**

“

I care less about what we do. I just want to see them.

- Felicity, the reason we built it

DRP · Group 02
Nelson · Lukas · Noah · James